Paterno Iam Diu

Benedict XV · 1919-11-24 · English

The Cry of the Children

TuHeE Hoty FAtHEr's APPEAL FOR THE LITTLE ONES OF CENTRAL EUROPE.

ENERABLE Brethren, Health and the Apostolic Blessing: Paternal feeling long since led Us to conclude from indications and to hope that with the ending of the frightful war and the awakening of the spirit of Christian charity the territories, especially those in the center of Europe, which had been ruined by want and famine would gradually be brought to a better state by the efforts and zeal of all good people. But the result has not been quite in accordance with Our expectation, for from everywhere is brought to Us the information that the crowded populations to whom We have referred are still suffering from a want of food and clothing al-

most greater than can be imagined. Meanwhile the bodily health of the weak declines and is destroyed, especially in the case of children, by whose grievous mis- fortune We are the more touched inasmuch as they are not only ignorant of and have had nothing to do with the internecine struggle by which We have seen almost the whole world ensanguined, but in the future will be the parents of new families who will show at their birth the weakness of their stock.

But We are somewhat relieved from these anxieties and troubles when We learn that well-intentioned people have formed societies for the purpose of preserving the lives of the young. As was fitting, Venerable Breth- ren, We did not hesitate to approve of this excelient project and support it with Our authority, for it was in conformity with the foremost duty of kindness which We owe to that tender age which is most dear to Christ Our Redeemer and has little power to bear and resist suffering. This is what We previously wanted done in a similar case, for you will remember that on a former occasion We did what We could to see that help was given to the children of the Belgians, almost utterly ex- hausted through hunger and want, and publicly appealed for them to the charity of Catholics, to whose general liberality it is, in a large measure, due that the needs of so many innocent children were provided for, their safety secured, their lives preserved; for when We. exhorted the Archbishops and Bishops of the United States of America to take up this noble work Our request met at once with a generous response from most of them. We recall the great success then attained not so much to praise men whose names are deservedly to be set down in the records of Christian charity as to impel all the Bishops of the world by Our voice and authority to strive most earnestly, in so far as they can influence their own people, to give effect to Our intention in this matter.

A GENERAL COLLECTION.

Therefore on the approach of the Feast of the Nativity of Our Lord Jesus Christ Our thoughts. turn spontane- ously to the distressed children of Europe, particularly Central Europe, who are suffering keenly from the want of the necessaries of life, and We feel all the greater

concern for these helpless little ones because they bring . before Us very distinctly the image of the Divine Child enduring for the love of men winter's cold and the lack of all things in the cave at Bethlehem. On this occasion nothing assuredly is more fitting than that We should implore for the innocent children the charity and mercy of the Faithful and also the kindness of all who hope for the salvation of the human race.

Accordingly We enjoin, Venerable Brethren, that to give effect to the proposal of which We have spoken, public prayers having been announced for the 28th of December, the Feast of the Holy Innocents, you shall see a collection is taken. from the Faithful. And in order that in this admirable rivalry in well-doing the interests of the childfen may be the more suitably attended to, in addition to the financial contribution an appeal is also to be made for foodstuffs, medicines, clothes and under- wear, which the people of those regions need more than any other kind of help. It is scarcely necessary to say how the offerings are to be divided and despatched to their destination; this task can be entrusted to the 3o0- cieties which, as We have stated, have been established for the purpose, or performed in any other way that may seem best.

We trust that the exhortations which We have delivered as a duty of the office of universal fatherhood Divinely committed to Us, will, though they concern Catholics above all, be received in a kindly spirit by all who have a feeling of humanity.

And in order that We may set others an example, al- though an abundance of resources and assistance is sought for from Us by people of all countries continually, We have decided to give, in accordance with

Our means, for the succor of the children in question the sum of one hundred thousand Italian lire.

Meanwhile, as an augury of success and a proof of Our paternal good will, We lovingly in the Lord impart the Apostolic Blessing to you, Venerable Brethren, and to all your clergy and people.

Given at St. Peter's, Rome, on the 24th of November, 1919, the sixth year of Our Pontificate.

BENeEpict XV, Pope.

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